

The Distributional Hypothesis

- **The distributional hypothesis:** words that are used and occur in the same contexts tend to have similar meanings (Harris, 1954)
- Distributional semantics represents the meaning of words as a distribution over the word's contexts
- A usage-based approach: a word gains its meaning by how it is used
- The approach has been studied in cognitive science as well
 - McDonald and Ramscar (2001) studied how occurrences of a word in context shift similarity ratings

McDonald, Scott, and Michael Ramscar. "Testing the distributional hypothesis: The influence of context on judgements of semantic similarity." *Proceedings of the Annual Meeting of the Cognitive Science Society*. Vol. 23. No. 23. 2001.